

The 6:15

FRIDAY · AUGUST 21, 2026

NO. 5

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Mon 8/24	Treasury Sec. Bessent press conference — details of Iran sanctions plan
Wed 8/26	Nvidia (NVDA) aft. close — rev. cons. ~\$91.85B vs. co. guide \$91.0B±2%; July PCE, Q2 GDP (2nd est.), durable goods, 8:30a (BEA); Lisa Cook's deadline to respond to White House removal letter
Thu 8/27	Marvell (MRVL) aft. close; jobless claims; Treasury 7Y note auction (announced 8/20); Jackson Hole symposium opens, through 8/29
Fri 8/28	Fed Chair Warsh's first Jackson Hole keynote
Mon 8/31	Treasury 7Y note settlement
Tue 9/16	Next FOMC decision
Lockup [NEW]	SpaceX (SPCX): ~319M shares came off lockup Thu 8/20, part of a staggered post-IPO release; stock fell 6% to \$131.86, below its \$135 IPO price for the first time since June

No primaries or elections confirmed in this window. OPEC+ 68th JMMC not until 10/4, outside window. Xi-Trump Washington summit 9/24, outside window — see Geopolitics. Tue 8/25 and Tue-Wed 9/1-9/2 omitted, nothing verified this run.

METRICS · ~6:20A ET FRI 8/21 UNLESS NOTED

Brent (ICE front)	\$94.17, +0.42% (Investing.com, real-time 6:15a ET); Thu close ~\$93.78
WTI (NYMEX front)	\$87.36, +0.61% (Yahoo Finance premkt) vs. \$86.19-86.31 on separate aggregators — unreconciled
Brent-WTI spread	~\$6.81 (same-source pairing, this morning)
UST 10Y / 30Y	4.71% / 5.25% (TradingEconomics, AM) vs. 4.65% / 5.19% official Wed 8/19 close 2Y not confirmed as of press time
DXY	98.80, +0.05%

S&P / Nasdaq-100 futures	+0.33% / +0.66% (Yahoo Finance, premarket)
VIX	16.01, +7.52% (one AM read) vs. 15.63, -2.37% (Yahoo live blog) — unreconciled
Gold (spot)	\$4,639.10, +1.48% (Yahoo, AM)
Nikkei 225 / Hang Seng	66,118, +1.21% / 25,698, +0.8% (Asia close)
Europe	Euro Stoxx 50 6,432, -0.2%; Stoxx 600 651, flat DAX/FTSE/CAC not verified this run
Retail gas, natl. avg. (AAA)	\$4.1092/gal (8/21) — highest on record for this calendar date

Crude sources of record: ICE Brent, NYMEX WTI front-month. Rates: Treasury.gov official close vs. live secondary quotes, flagged where they diverge.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure	Day 173 (straits.live, 10:16 UTC 8/21)
Transits vs. baseline	1 vessel on 8/16 vs. 73/day pre-crisis (IMF/Oxford PortWatch AIS, ~1wk lag)
Weekly transits	73 total, wk of 8/10-8/16, down from 91 prior week (Lloyd's List Intelligence); non-Iranian-linked 43; 22+ vessels in / 21+ out of Gulf
Incidents, 24-72h	1 hijacking (sanctioned tanker diverted toward Somalia), last 24h; multiple boardings, Gulf of Aden, last 72h (straits.live); 1 seafarer killed, bulker strike wk of 8/19, responsibility unconfirmed (Lloyd's)
Incidents, cumulative	80 UKMTO-confirmed (period 3/1-8/4) — stale, predates 8/13-19 attacks, not re-published this run
Blockade (CENTCOM)	64 merchant vessels redirected, 3 disabled, 2 boarded (cumulative, via Lloyd's)
Dark tankers	28 AIS-dark of 264 screened, last 24h (straits.live)
War-risk premium	40.0x pre-crisis; ~\$10.0M/VLCC passage (straits.live)
Stranded vessels	473 holding position (straits.live)
Crisis Pressure Index	90/100, "Extreme" (straits.live composite)

Four distinct universes, not netted: PortWatch counts satellite-tracked AIS transits with a multi-day lag; Lloyd's List aggregates weekly commercial transits >10,000 dwt with Iran-link attribution, preliminary/revised; straits.live blends broker war-risk quotes with same-day dark-ship detection; UKMTO logs confirmed security incidents, a different count entirely from transits. Don't average or net across them.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	No reported roster moves in the last 24 hours.
Knicks	Josh Hart extension (eligible since 8/15) still unsigned; The Athletic reporting (8/20) pegs the expected deal near 3yr/\$60-62M, well under his \$132M max.
Northwestern	No reported moves; off-season.

LEAD

IRAN / MARKETS

Iran missiles hit UAE waters, Abu Dhabi cuts all trade with Tehran, and Trump declares "Economic D-Day"

Iran fired two ballistic missiles toward the UAE early Wednesday; one splashed down inside Emirati territorial waters, the other landed outside them. Iran denied firing them. [NEW] The UAE's Ministry of Foreign Affairs responded within hours: spokesperson Afra Al Hameli announced an immediate suspension of "all trade, commercial exchange and financial transactions" with Iran, citing "regional escalations that undermine regional and international peace and security." [NEW] The UAE is Iran's second-largest trading partner after China, with non-oil bilateral trade running into the tens of billions annually, so the cutoff removes one of Tehran's last major open channels at a moment its economy is already visibly strained. [fact: precise trade-volume figures not independently reconfirmed this run; read: the speed of the response — hours, not weeks — suggests the missile launch itself forced Abu Dhabi's hand rather than a slow-building policy shift] The strike adds to a cumulative UAE homeland toll that has reached at least 12 killed and 200-plus injured since the war widened to include direct hits on Emirati

territory. [NEW figure; dating of individual prior strikes not reconfirmed this run]

Hours later, Trump escalated on a separate track. In a Truth Social post Wednesday he declared Iran would face "economic warfare and isolation on an unprecedented scale" — an "ECONOMIC D-DAY" — after Tehran "failed to take" the chance to make a deal. [NEW] The targets he named were specific: oil smuggling networks, swap lines, cash transfers, exchange houses, ship registries and front companies — the plumbing Iran uses to move sanctioned crude and money. He also threatened that any country whose financial institutions, businesses, airports or government entities give Iran a "lifeline" would itself face "TREMENDOUS Economic Consequences." [NEW] Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent told CNBC that Washington would impose the "toughest sanctions in history" to "collapse" the Iranian government and called on other nations — China by name — to join. [NEW] Bessent is due to unveil the plan's specifics at a press conference Monday. [NEW, forward-looking — see Board]

China pushed back immediately, calling the sanctions push unlikely to resolve the underlying dispute; Iran's foreign ministry rejected the "Economic D-Day" framing outright, calling it a distraction from America's own economic strains. [NEW] [read: this morning's reporting has Trump naming China's Gulf oil purchases specifically — the administration is trying to force a choice Beijing has avoided all war: sanctions compliance, or continued discounted-crude flows — three weeks before Xi's Sept. 24 Washington summit; see Geopolitics]

The shift from missiles to money is deliberate framing on Washington's side, but oil isn't reading it as de-escalation. Brent

traded to \$94.17 this morning (+0.42%, 6:15a ET), up from Thursday's roughly \$93.78 close and further still from the \$88.52 settle two issues ago — a run of nearly \$6 in a week. [NEW] WTI is bid near \$87.36, though earlier aggregator reads this morning put it closer to \$86.20-86.31; the quotes haven't reconciled. [flag: WTI unreconciled] The Hormuz numbers underneath the price move keep deteriorating on their own logic, independent of today's news: a single vessel transited the strait on Aug. 16 against a 73-per-day pre-crisis baseline, and straits.live logged a tanker hijacking — a sanctioned vessel diverted toward Somalia — in the past 24 hours alone. [DEVELOPING; see Board, Iran & Hormuz]

Equities are absorbing this alongside a bond selloff that predates today's news: the 10-year is near 4.71% this morning versus an official 4.65% Wednesday close, and stocks are on track for a weekly loss even with futures modestly higher (S&P +0.33%, Nasdaq-100 +0.66%). [NEW] The yield move is the more immediate market story for equities — this morning's market wrap explicitly ties the selloff to pressure on capital-intensive AI names, Nvidia and SpaceX among them, five days before Nvidia's own print. [read: rising real rates are doing to AI-capex stocks what oil alone hasn't managed this week] Gold is up sharply too, to \$4,639 (+1.48%) — a straightforward flight-to-safety read — though two sources this morning disagree sharply on the VIX's actual move, one showing it up more than 7%, another down more than 2%. [flag: VIX unreconciled]

POLITICS

The Lisa Cook standoff enters its final stretch: the White House's Aug. 26 deadline for her to respond to renewed mortgage-fraud

allegations is five days out, and neither side has signaled a resolution. [DEVELOPING] Cook continues to dispute the allegations, and independent reporting on her financial records has undermined parts of the administration's case, though that hasn't slowed the process. [DEVELOPING] That date is no longer just a Fed-independence story on its own — it now lands in the same cluster as Nvidia's earnings and the July PCE/Q2 GDP prints, with Fed Chair Warsh's first Jackson Hole keynote following two days later. [read: however Trump resolves the Cook question will be read by markets as a data point on Fed independence right as Warsh takes the same stage] Separately, the funding gap between the Senate's Dec. 11 continuing resolution and the House's Dec. 4 version remains unclosed; the House stays in recess until early September. [DEVELOPING, unchanged since Issue No. 4] [read: the contrast is notable — Bessent's Iran sanctions campaign needs no congressional sign-off and moves within days, while the funding gap sits idle for lack of the same]

ECONOMICS

Wednesday's FOMC minutes described a committee closer to a rate hike than at any point in a decade: a 9-3 hold at the July 28-29 meeting, which kept the funds rate at 3.5-3.75%, with three regional Fed presidents — Cleveland's Beth Hammack, Minneapolis's Neel Kashkari and Dallas's Lorie Logan — dissenting in favor of a quarter-point increase. [NEW] Two non-voting hawks, Kansas City's Jeffrey Schmid and St. Louis's Alberto Musalem, said separately they'd have backed a hike too had they held a vote; no Board governor joined the dissent. [NEW] Many participants judged further tightening "likely to be necessary" if inflation doesn't recede. Markets aren't fully buying the hawkishness — September hike odds

on CME FedWatch sit at 31-34%, still down hard from roughly 60% three weeks ago, since the minutes describe a meeting that predates the softer retail-sales and consumer-sentiment prints that followed it. [NEW, supersedes prior issue's estimate] Initial jobless claims fell to 206,000 for the week ended Aug. 15, below the 210,000 consensus and down from a revised 212,000; continuing claims rose to 1,799,000, above expectations. [NEW] [read: the split — low layoffs, slower re-hiring — is the same low-hire, low-fire pattern that's defined 2026, and it's why the Fed's hawks and doves are both able to point to the same claims data as support] Treasury yields are corroborating the hawkish read more than the futures market is: the 10-year touched a 20-month high of 4.75% this week before settling back near 4.64-4.71% across sources, and the 30-year hit a 19-year high of 5.34% before easing under 5.2%. [NEW]

BUSINESS

Four of the week's most-watched retail prints are in, and the through-line is a Q2 that looked strong on the surface but leaned on one-time items. Home Depot beat Tuesday — adjusted EPS \$4.92 vs. \$4.73 consensus, revenue \$47.86B (+5.7% YoY) vs. \$47.27B expected — but held full-year guidance rather than raising it. [NEW] Target's Wednesday beat looked enormous on paper (EPS \$4.11 vs. \$2.35 consensus) but roughly \$1.65 of that per-share figure came from a \$994M pretax tariff-refund benefit; underlying comp sales grew 3.8%, with digital comps up 8.7%. [NEW; flag: headline beat overstates organic strength] Lowe's also beat Wednesday (EPS \$4.40) but issued muted annual guidance; TJX reported the same day, though its specific figures weren't independently reconfirmed this run. [flag] Walmart's Thursday print showed revenue up 5.9% to \$187.94B and operating income up 28.8%, helped by a \$2.9B tariff

refund of its own; GAAP EPS actually fell to \$0.80 from \$0.88 a year ago, though adjusted EPS of \$0.81 beat, and e-commerce grew 23% globally even as some reporting flagged store-level softness. [NEW] [read: tariff refunds and one-time items are doing real work propping up per-share numbers across all four prints — a cleaner read on consumer health won't be available until those roll off] Outside retail, SpaceX's post-IPO lockup began releasing Thursday — roughly 319M shares — and the stock dropped 6% to \$131.86, its first close below the \$135 IPO price since the June debut. [NEW] Nvidia holds a stake that has fallen alongside it: \$21B when Q2 closed (disclosed 8/14) to \$17.2B now. [NEW] [read: the lockup, not the bond selloff alone, looks like the proximate driver of this week's SpaceX move, though the two are reinforcing each other]

TECHNOLOGY

Nothing shipped this window on the frontier-model side — Gemini 3.5 Pro remains undelivered as of its last confirmed check (Aug. 13), missing a third target, while Grok 5's full API access may slip into Q3. [unchanged, DEVELOPING] The more immediate tech story this morning is markets, not models: this week's bond selloff is the explicit reason cited for pressure on capital-intensive AI names — Nvidia and SpaceX by name in this morning's market wrap — arriving five days ahead of Nvidia's own Aug. 26 print, where consensus sits near \$91.85B in revenue against the company's own \$91.0B±2% guide. [NEW] In the background, China's rare-earth export controls remain the structural risk under the chip supply chain: gallium prices are up 123% and germanium 203% since Beijing's restrictions on 10 U.S. firms (6/22) and 14 EU firms (7/24), with the IEA warning that full enforcement could put \$6.5T of downstream production at risk globally. [background, not new this

window; diplomatic suspension of the broader controls runs through Nov. 10-27] That's the leverage sitting behind Trump's demand this week that China help isolate Iran economically — see Lead, Geopolitics.

GEOPOLITICS

Russia hit Kyiv with its largest barrage in weeks Thursday: at least 44 missiles, 39 intercepted per Ukraine's air force, with strikes reaching civilian infrastructure near a children's hospital; killed counts across reporting range from 12 to 18. [NEW] Moscow said it struck "military-industrial facilities, a transportation and logistics centre, and warehouses." Zelenskyy's domestic position is deteriorating at the same time: anti-corruption investigators raided the home of deputy chief of staff Iryna Mudra over an alleged \$3.4M money-laundering scheme tied to bail payments for a former energy minister already facing the biggest graft case of his presidency; he fired her Wednesday. [NEW] Former defense minister Mykhailo Fedorov released a video the same week calling for elections before the war ends and describing a "systemic crisis of governance." [NEW] [read: a wartime leader facing an internal corruption reckoning and an election push from a rival has less room to negotiate from strength, at the same moment Washington and Moscow both have leverage plays in motion] Separately, China's public rebuff of Trump's Iran sanctions push — and his pointed naming of Beijing's Gulf oil purchases — lands three weeks before Xi's Sept. 24 Washington summit, adding a fresh friction point to a meeting already carrying export-control and rare-earth tension. [DEVELOPING; see Lead]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Trump added a new escalatory line this week beyond the economic-warfare push: he told reporters Iran's regime is "crazy" and would use a nuclear weapon "without question" if it had one — rhetoric

that reads as justification for the sanctions campaign rather than a new nuclear-intelligence claim. [NEW; flag: single write-up, no underlying intelligence cited] CENTCOM's running blockade tally, updated this week: 64 merchant vessels redirected, three disabled, two boarded since the campaign began. [NEW figures via Lloyd's List] A sanctioned tanker was hijacked and diverted toward Somalia in the past 24 hours, and multiple boardings were reported in the Gulf of Aden over the past 72 hours — incidents distinct from, and additive to, the missile and drone strikes tracked separately on the Board. [NEW] One seafarer was killed in a bulker strike the week of Aug. 19; responsibility is unconfirmed, and there's an unconfirmed report of an Emirati-linked tanker seizure near Qeshm Island. [NEW; flag: single-sourced] ADNOC, meanwhile, is building out its own tanker fleet even as its chartered vessels keep getting hit: the state oil company bought six VLCCs and five VLGCs for a combined \$1.3B. [NEW; read: hedging exposure to a war-risk insurance market now pricing 40x pre-crisis premiums, rather than waiting for the strait to reopen] The freight market is pricing the same risk: TD3C Middle East Gulf-to-China earnings now exceed \$520,000/day. [NEW] UKMTO's last published cumulative incident count — 80, covering March 1 through Aug. 4 — predates the past two weeks' attacks and hasn't been re-published this run. [flag: stale]

SPORTS

Yankees	Beat Baltimore 6-1 Thu 8/20 (Cole 6 solid IP; García Jr., Spencer Jones HRs), completing a 3-game sweep. 71-55, 2nd AL East, 5.0 GB Tampa Bay, No. 1 AL Wild Card.
Knicks	Off-season, no game. Hart extension (see Transactions) still unsigned.
Northwestern	Off-season, no game. Opens Sat 9/5 vs. South Dakota State; Aidan Chiles the frontrunner at QB over Nicco

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since Issue No. 4: the Oman shipping-lane deal's status (no update located this run); USS Abraham Lincoln relief-carrier rotation; the Khamenei command-reshuffle roster; CoreWeave/Cisco/Applied Materials earnings detail (now established). Watching for next issue: Bessent's Monday press conference detailing the Iran sanctions plan; Lisa Cook's Aug. 26 response; Nvidia's Aug. 26 print; the VIX and WTI readings flagged unreconciled this issue; TJX's specific Q2 figures.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.